

WELL BEGUN OR HALF DONE?

India's maiden victory in the Nehru Cup, corporate involvement and a new premier league could revolutionise Indian football

■ **By Swagata Sen**

The last time India won a major international football tournament, Indira Gandhi was still the prime minister, Rajesh Khanna was the king of romance, Ambassadors and Fiats ruled the Indian streets and Baichung Bhutia was not even born. As India defeated Syria—a team placed 30 places higher in the FIFA world ranking—in the Nehru Cup finals in Delhi's Ambedkar Stadium, the ignominy of being placed along the likes of Sierra Leone, Vanuatu and Madagascar with a ranking on the wrong side of the 160s was almost forgotten. As was the fact that the world's second most populous nation, once an Asian footballing powerhouse had never made it to the FIFA World Cup.

In the space of 12 days, India's ranking climbed from 168 to 151 and will probably move up even more, once

the latest FIFA rankings are released later this month. It is the logical conclusion of Indian football coach Bob Houghton's theory of "keeping the players happy to get results". All India Football Federation (AIFF) General Secretary Alberto Colaco emphatically says the Nehru Cup victory was not a fluke. "A lot of pain were taken to see that the team was well prepared. During a visit to Portugal, I requested

the Portuguese league to host us for three weeks. This provided ideal preparation and also good match practice," he says. That the Syrians are no pushovers in football is clear from the fact that they are playing in the Under-17 World Cup currently on in South Korea.

Over the last two decades Indian football had slipped to such depths that there was only one to go and that was up. But more than anything else, the Houghton factor has helped. Once the youngest-ever football coach in England, he was coach of Sweden's Malmo FC that reached the European Cup final in 1979 (today's Champions League) before taking on assignments with the Chinese national team and clubs in the Middle East later.

FIFA President Sepp Blatter's visit earlier this year seems to have set the ball rolling for Indian football. Blatter arrived with seven experts who gave pointers on how India's soccer infrastructure could be improved. A task force was set up to hone



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